Public Space is Not Neutral

Co-Designing Safety Through Women's Experience

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UNIVERSITY OF LEEDS

Public space is shared.

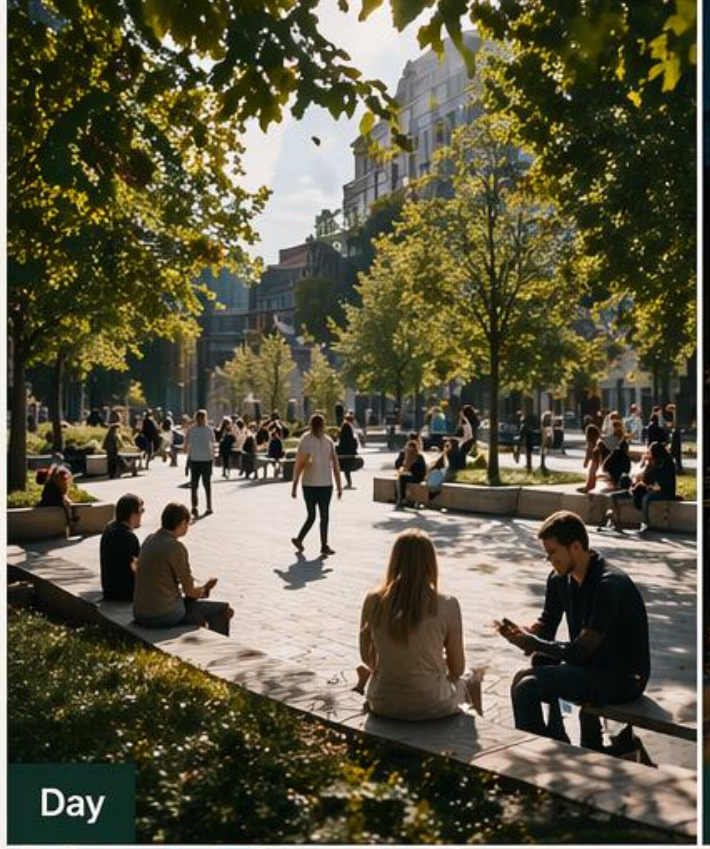
We often describe public space as shared, but in reality, it is **experienced very differently** depending on who you are.

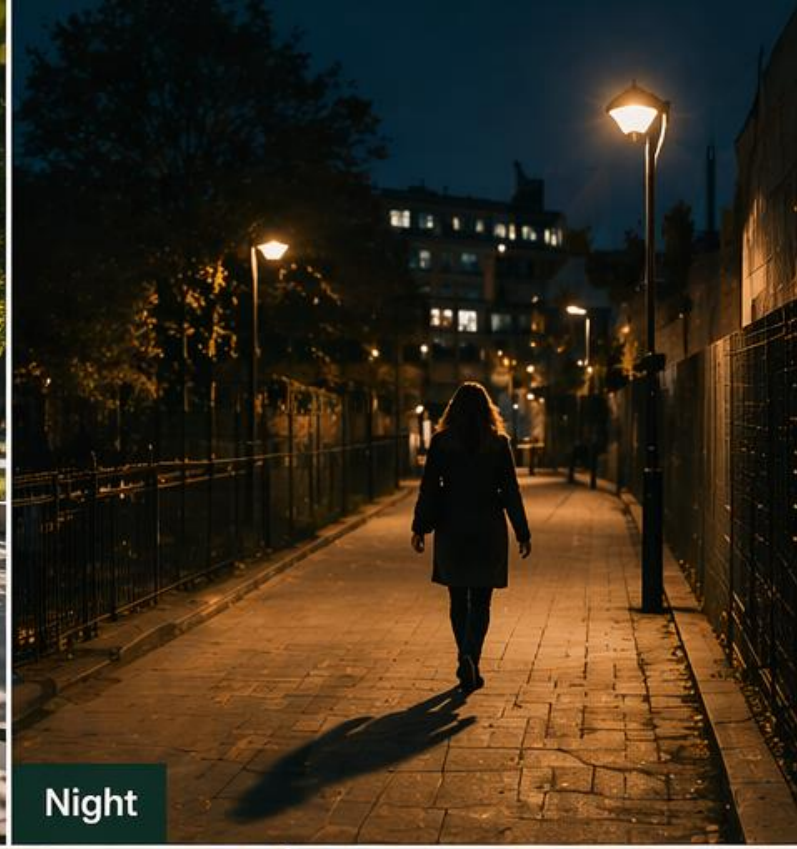
Different people

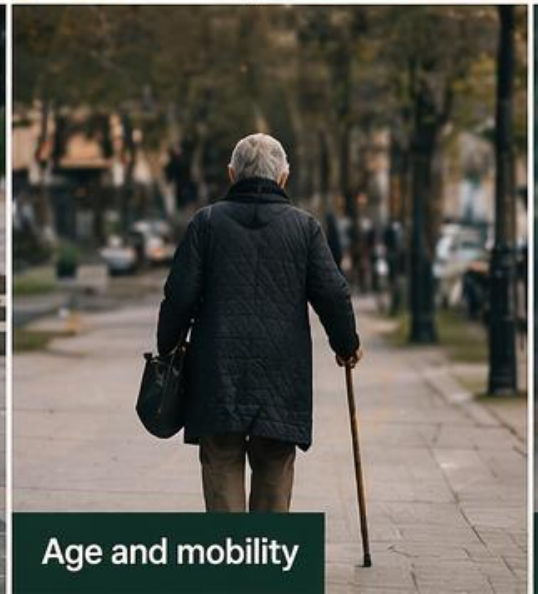
Different times

Different places

Different routes







The Paradox of Fear

Women consistently report **higher levels of fear** in public space For example, in the UK, the majority of women feel unsafe walking alone at night.

Yet statistically, men are **more likely** to be victims of certain forms of public violence.

This disconnect is what we refer to as the **paradox of fear**, and it has **real spatial consequences.**

FEAR IS HIGHER, DESPITE LOWER EXPOSURE TO VIOLENCE

FEAR OF WALKING ALONE AT NIGHT

% who agree they would feel unsafe walking alone at night in their local area (UK, 2021)

~2 in 3

women feel unsafe (69%)

VICTIMS OF STRANGER VIOLENCE

Police recorded victims of violence by a stranger (England & Wales, 2022/23)

Men are more likely to be victims of stranger violence.

Fear shapes how we move, when we go, and where we belong.

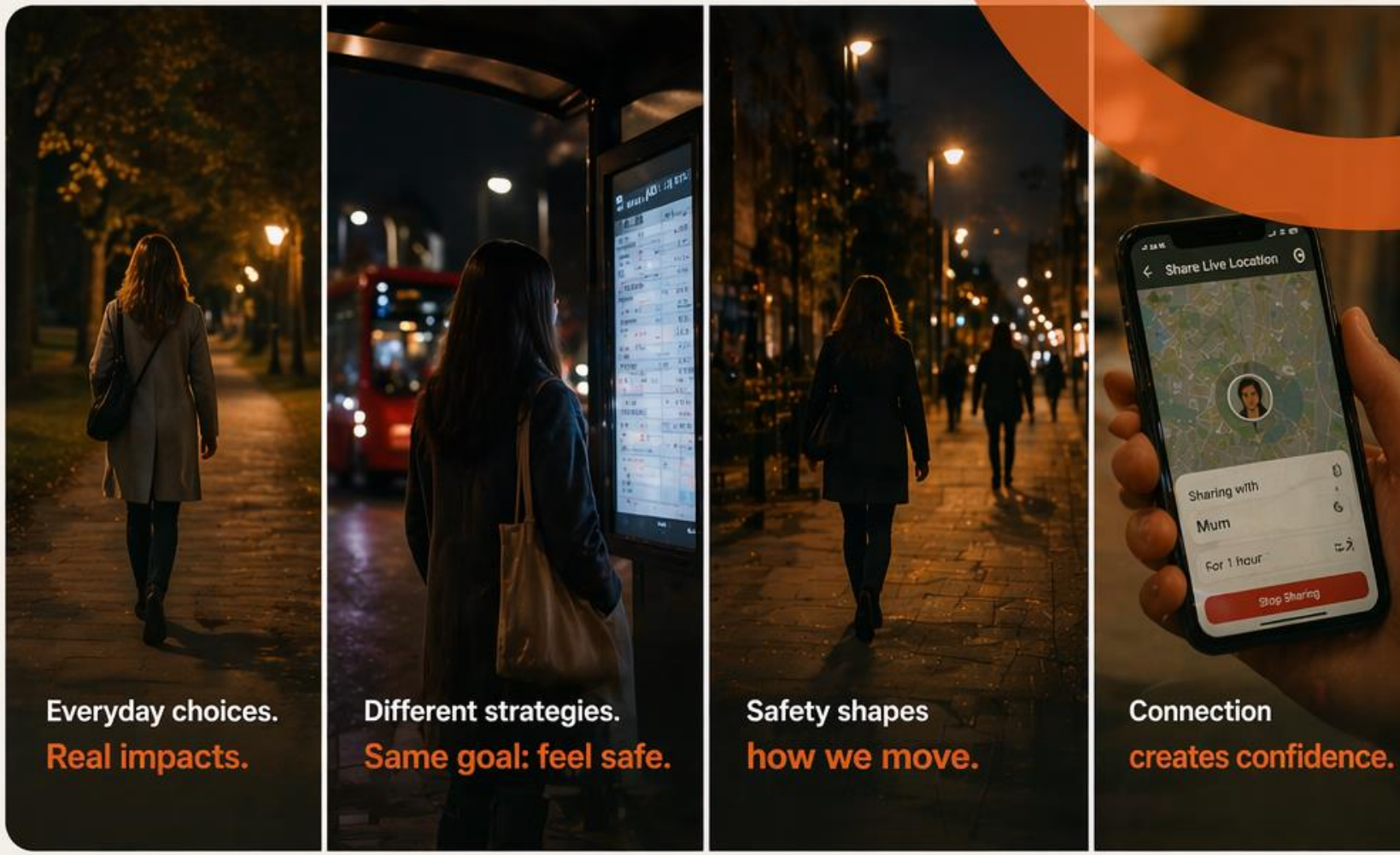
Designing Around Fear

Avoid routes or places
Choosing longer or less direct routes, or avoiding certain areas altogether.

Change time of travel
Adjusting when you go out to avoid darkness or quieter times.

Seek light and activity
Preferring well-lit, busy and visible spaces over isolated ones.

Stay connected (calls, messages)
Keeping in touch with someone, sharing location, or calling while travelling.



Everyday choices. **Real impacts.**

Different strategies. **Same goal: feel safe.**

Safety shapes **how we move.**

Connection **creates confidence.**

THE EVIDENCE

Over 50%
of women report changing behaviour to feel safer.
(UN Women UK)

38%
avoid certain places entirely due to safety concerns.
(González-Moreno et al., 2022)

Many women
alter routes, transport choices, and routines.
(Stark & Meschik, 2018)

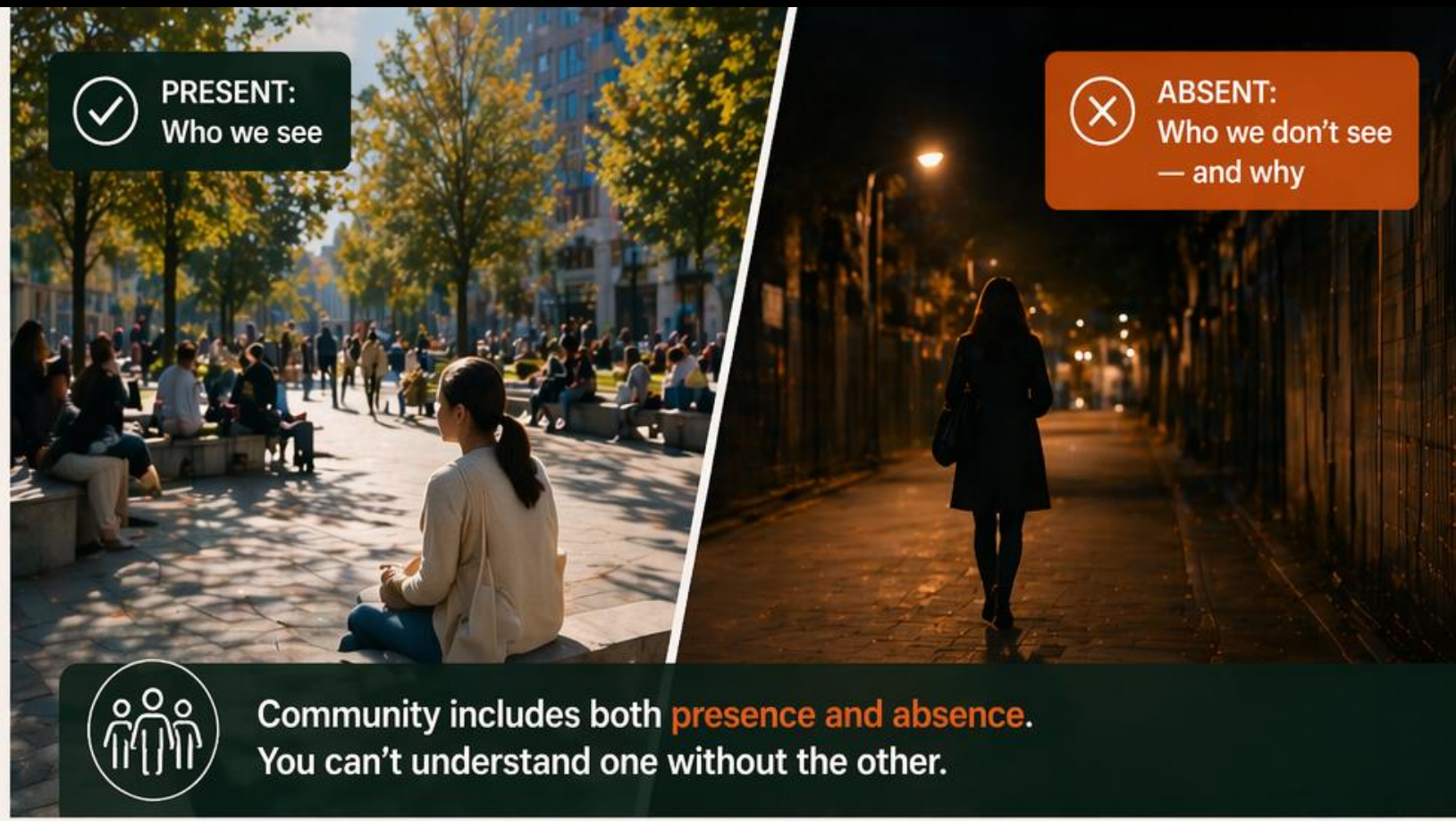
Who is the Community?

Community is not fixed.

Those who use space
Those who feel safe, welcome and included.

Those who avoid it
Those who alter, limit or avoid public space due to fear or barriers.

Different experiences overlap
Experiences of gender, age, race, disability, class and identity intersect.



Community includes both presence and absence.
You can't understand one without the other.

EVIDENCE FROM RESEARCH

Fear contributes to women's exclusion from public space.
(Day, 2001; Koskela & Pain, 2000)

Public space is shaped by presence AND absence.
(Zárate, 2014)

Gendered experiences create unequal access and participation.
(Listerborn, 2016)

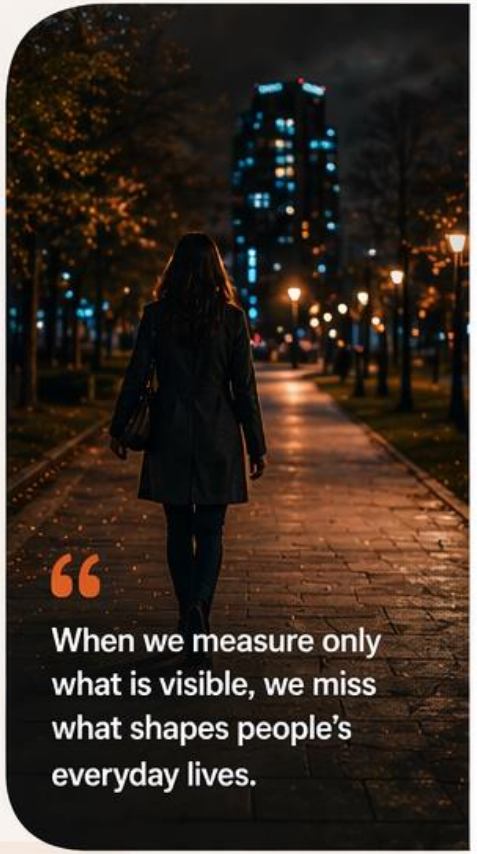
Recognising Need

Need is not always visible.

Not just crime data
Crime statistics capture only what is reported, not what is felt.

Perception matters
Fear and perception influence how people experience and use space.

Behaviour reveals gaps
Everyday choices and adaptations highlight hidden inequailties.



> When we measure only what is visible, we miss what shapes people's everyday lives.

EVIDENCE THAT NEED IS OFTEN INVISIBLE

Fear of crime often exceeds actual risk.
Across many studies, women report higher fear of crime than men, even though men are more likely to be victims of violence.
(Pain, 2001; Valentine, 1989)

68% of women in the UK feel unsafe walking alone at night (vs. 29% of men).
(ONS, 2021)

Traditional metrics overlook lived experience and perception.
Conventional safety assessments focus on reported crime and footfall, missing the emotional and gendered dimensions of safety.
(Listerborn, 2016)

Over 80% of women say safety is a key factor in how they use public spaces.
(UN-Habitat, 2023)

Everyday behaviour reveals hidden spatial inequalities.
Women adapt routes, travel times and modes, and avoid places—changing how they access opportunities and services.
(Koskela, 1997; Stark & Meschik, 2018)

Over 50% of women report changing their behaviour (e.g., route, timing, transport) to feel safer.
(UN Women UK, 2021)

These findings are consistent across countries and contexts: women consistently report higher fear of crime than men, regardless of actual victimisation rates. *(OECD, 2022)*

RECENT DATA SNAPSHOT

68%
of women in the UK feel unsafe walking alone at night (vs. 29% of men).
(ONS, 2021)

46%
of women globally say they do not feel safe in public spaces such as streets, parks or public transport.
(UN Women, 2023)

38%
of women avoid certain places entirely due to safety concerns.
(González-Moreno et al., 2022)

What we measure shapes what we design.

To design safe, inclusive and just public spaces, we must design with the people who experience them.

CO-PRODUCTION: A BETTER WAY TO RECOGNISE NEED

Co-production involves communities, especially those most affected, in identifying problems, shaping solutions and evaluating outcomes. It leads to more relevant, trusted and equitable public spaces.

WHY CO-PRODUCTION WORKS

- Captures diverse lived experiences and local knowledge
- Builds trust and legitimacy in decision-making
- Produces solutions that are context-specific and fairer
- Improves uptake, ownership and long-term impact

KEY REFERENCES

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- Needham, B. (2008). Realising the potential of co-production. *Public Management Review.*
- Brandsen, T., van Dooren, W., & de Jong, J. (2012). Co-production and co-creation. *Public Management Review.*
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From Research to Practice

WESAFSPACE Project

Capturing lived experience of safety

Understanding how people (especially women and marginalised groups) experience and navigate public spaces.

Participatory methods:

- Mapping
- Walks
- Workshops

Translating insights into:

- Design strategies
- Policy recommendations

Informing local decision-making

Insights shared with Leeds City Council to influence planning, design and policy.

Leeds CITY COUNCIL

> Through this project, we worked with communities to understand how safety is experienced — and how these insights can inform design and policy.

1. Listen

We listen to experiences often missed by data.

2. Understand

We explore places together through walks and workshops.

3. Co-produce

We co-create ideas for safer, more inclusive spaces.

FROM INSIGHT TO IMPACT

Lived experience & perception → Spatial insight & evidence → Design strategies & solutions → Policy recommendations → Local decision-making & change

Designing Belonging

A pathway from lived experience to inclusive, safe public space

FEAR

Emotions and perceptions of threat influence how people feel in space.

BEHAVIOUR

People adapt their movement, routes and activities to manage risk.

NEED

Behaviour reveals hidden needs and gaps in how space functions.

DESIGN

Design decisions shape experiences, inclusion and a sense of belonging.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE TELLS US

Fear shapes how space is used.

Fear of crime often outweighs actual risk and influences everyday decisions, especially for women.

(Pain, 2001; Valentine, 1989; Chataway, 2018)

Behaviour reveals hidden needs.

Everyday mobility practices and adaptations highlight spatial inequalities and unmet needs.

(Koskela, 1997; Stark & Meschik, 2018; Hanson & Pratt, 1995)

Design determines who belongs.

Urban design and planning shape access, comfort and belonging in public space.

(Listerborn, 2016; Low, 2000; Madge, 1997)

Women's safety is a key determinant of access to and use of public space worldwide. *(UN-Habitat, 2020)*

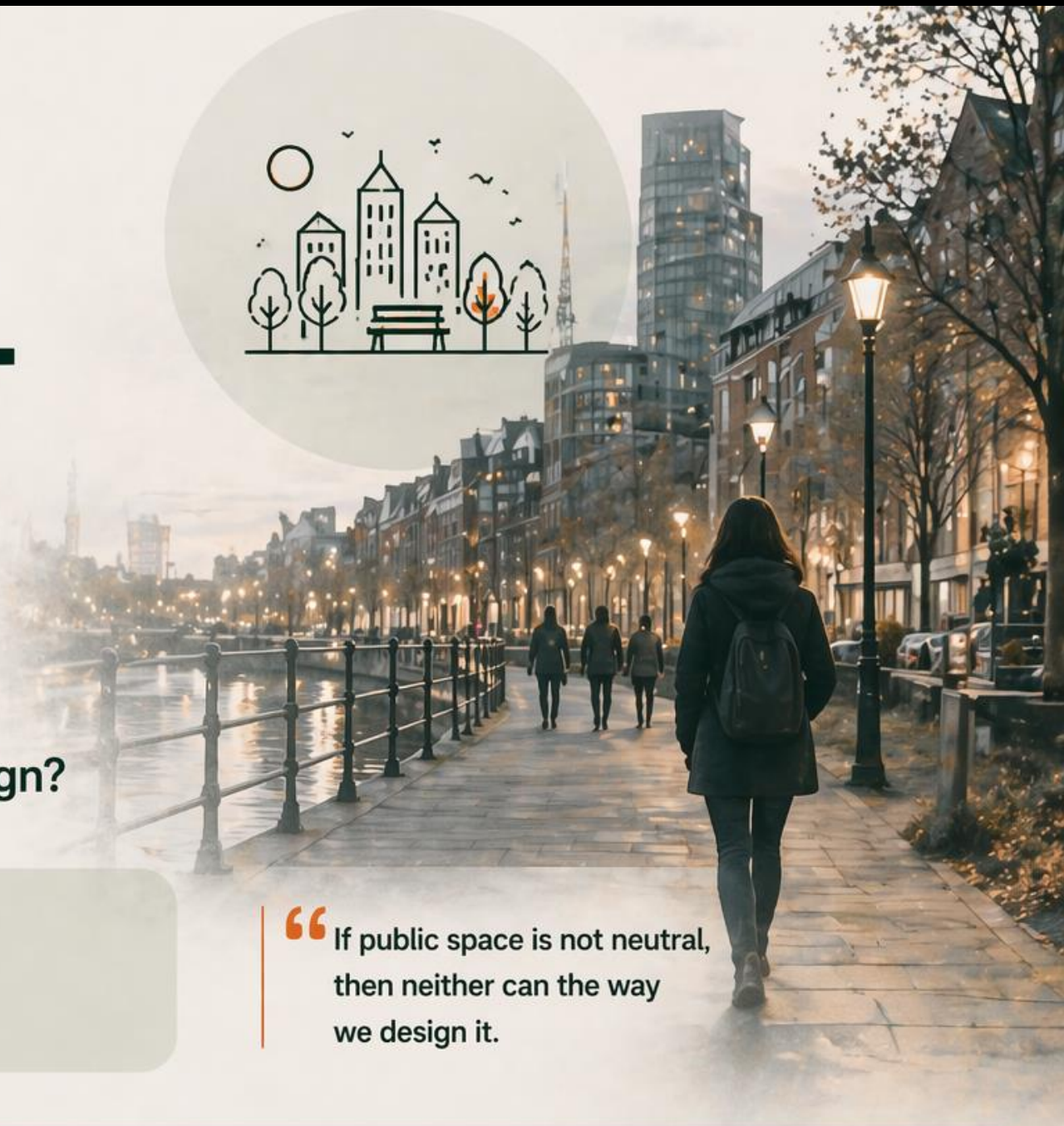
> If public space is to be democratic, it must be experienced as safe, accessible and inclusive by all. *(Fainstein, 2010)*

Public space cannot be truly shared if it is not experienced as safe.

Who feels safe here — and why?

And who doesn't —
and what does that mean for design?

Co-designing safety means designing for belonging.



> If public space is not neutral, then neither can the way we design it.

THANK YOU

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